

Ghiglia: "Digital civic education should be taught from elementary school"

The digital age is not merely an evolution of the Internet but a new discovery of fire. It is necessary, even through the simple knowledge of words often taken for granted without understanding their meaning, to lay the foundations for a new "digital free will." An excerpt from the preface of the book "Digital Civic Education. Essential ABC" by Agostino Ghiglia

Intervention by Agostino Ghiglia, Member of the Authority for the Protection of Personal Data (AgendaDigitale, September 18, 2023)

For so-called "digital natives," that is, those who have bypassed toy cars and dolls to rush to strain their little fingers on a "touch" screen, digital life seems natural; they appreciate its speed, simplicity, interactivity, but how much do they know about the tool they have in their hands or the consequences of its use for themselves and for the World? Too often the answer is: too little.

When did we start learning?

About 6,000 years ago, in Mesopotamia, some human beings began to use written signs for counting and numbering. A few millennia later, the Egyptians developed 22 hieroglyphs representing the consonants of their language, plus a 23rd that probably served as an initial or final vowel in a word.

A few millennia later, the Chinese arrived with their ideograms, and subsequently, the populations settled in Central America with their logograms, easier to paint than to define!

We know, therefore, more or less, when human beings began to write, but the real question is: when did they start to learn? I do not believe there is a precise answer, except with approximations of a few hundred thousand years, but, all in all, that is not so important: the fundamental thing is that humans, in order to evolve, had to begin to learn, that is, to know in order to grow, live, and survive.

Who knows how many people were burned to "discover" fire or, rather, to use it, to understand its risks until they managed to use it "consciously," with awareness, gradually comprehending its enormous potential.

We modern human beings, fortunately, slowly but steadily, for about 500,000 years, knowledge after experience, understanding after comprehension, have gained education, that is, a process of growth in intellectual and practical behaviors that should give us awareness, teaching us to live in an increasingly complex society.

Without invoking philosophers and sociologists, educators and wizards, the first thing we are educated about, before good and evil, is what is good for us or what harms us: eat an apple a day, do not swallow the whole egg (not even with the shell), etc.

Subsequently, we are educated to distinguish good from evil, and here it gets tough, much tougher... Because while the goodness of the apple and the danger of the eggshell are universally accepted, history, religions, and environmental conditions have, so far (and I emphasize so far), caused many different interpretations of what is good and what is evil. Will it still be so with the progressive standardization of the technological languages of the digital age, or will we arrive at a new global perception of reality (of good and evil) mediated by the tools and common terms referred to in this booklet?

A new free will for the digital age

I wonder if, nowadays, the ever-celebrated "free will" can still come to our aid. Good Saint Augustine of Hippo (who later became part of the same team as Saint Thomas Aquinas) argued that human beings have the ability to choose between good and evil; Luther, passionate about predestination, denied free will, Erasmus of Rotterdam brought it back into vogue while Descartes sought truth through doubt... Someone may be wondering the point of this super-synthetic philosophical digression; well, the point, in the digital age, can be summarized in three words: understand, know, choose (good or evil).

The writer indeed starts from the conviction that the digital age, with its supersonic development, is not a simple evolution of the Internet but a new discovery of fire, and that thousands of years of experience, tradition, development, and evolution can provide us with the minimal knowledge bases to

avoid current and future technological burns; that it is necessary, even through the simple knowledge of words often taken for granted without knowing (but only sometimes distorting their meaning) their significance, to lay the foundations for a new “digital free will.”

I know, it seems easy, but easy is not taken for granted, and as my unforgettable high school Physics professor often repeated: “You must learn the simple things well...”.

Living in hyperhistory

Living in Hyperhistory – borrowing the enlightening and evocative, but also imaginative, if you will, definition from Luciano Floridi – in which the interaction between humans and machines is becoming predominant or, worse, the growing dependence of human beings on machines, and inhabiting the Infosphere (a digital environment in which we spend increasing parts of our lives, the so-called onlife), it is essential to start from the ABC, that is, from the basic knowledge of simple things (terms).

Unlike the past, we have transitioned (and have been made to transition) from a “materially lived life” to an “activated life,” a life...

extremely real but virtually passed, “remotely,” studying, working, communicating, loving; always connected, always on display, much more exposed than we often manage to perceive. “We all seem to be placed on a stage and feel obliged to put on a show” (C. Bukowski).

Digital Twins to Protect

Anyone of us who has one or more accounts and uses them on platforms or social media, or has a voice assistant or communicates via their smartphone, will have one or more digital twins.

In the morning when we wake up to check the time on our phone, we also awaken our digital twin, which, from that moment on, will begin to grow with the flow of our day, accumulating more and more information from our behaviors: how much we walk, how much we browse the web, how much sports we do, where we go – through our calendar – and with whom.

If we add basic functions such as social media browsing and purchases on platforms, or even just accept the profiling cookies of a website, we awaken (or activate others) a multitude of digital twins that will feed on the information we pour into them, or through them.

Thus, we could have an Amazon twin, a Google twin, a TikTok twin, a Facebook/Meta twin, an Apple twin, an Android twin... And we who, perhaps, thought we were only children or had a family limited to physical relatives!

Conclusions

With this booklet, we aim to make a humble contribution to fill a gap, simply explaining the simple things of our daily onlife, often using Anglophone terms that are not always known or, at least, sufficiently understood: “Learning without thinking is labor wasted; thinking without learning (understanding...) is dangerous” (Confucius).